Expensely

Smart Offline Expense Manager

Personal Software Development Project

Developer: Thanoj Buddhima
Platform: Android / Flutter
Repository: `github.com/ThanojBuddhima/expenseAPK`

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Abstract

Expensely is a cross-platform, offline-first mobile expense management application developed with Flutter and Dart. It enables users to record income and expenses, manage multiple accounts and categories, set monthly budgets, and visualize financial data through analytics charts—all stored locally on the device using SQLite. Security features include optional 4-digit PIN lock and biometric authentication. The application supports light/dark/device themes, multi-currency formatting, first-time onboarding, and a built-in calculator. This report documents the project's architecture, implementation, testing, and release process as a professional portfolio case study.

Keywords: Expense Management, Flutter, SQLite, Offline-First, Mobile Application, Personal Finance, Biometric Authentication, Budget Tracking.

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Chapter 1

Project Overview

1.1 Project Summary

Expensely is a modern offline-first personal finance management application developed using Flutter. The application enables users to track income, expenses, budgets, accounts, and financial trends while keeping all data stored locally on the device.

The project was created to provide a privacy-focused alternative to cloud-based expense tracking applications. Users can manage finances without creating accounts, subscriptions, or requiring internet connectivity.

1.2 Problem Statement

Existing expense tracking applications often:

- Require internet connectivity for core features
- Store sensitive financial data on third-party servers
- Include complex onboarding or subscription models
- Lack integrated budgeting and analytics in a single offline package

There is a need for a lightweight, privacy-focused, offline-capable expense manager suitable for Android devices.

1.3 Goals and Objectives

1.3.1 Main Goal

Design and implement **Expensely**, a fully functional offline expense manager that prioritizes user privacy and ease of use.

1.3.2 Specific Objectives

1. Implement income and expense transaction management with search and filtering
2. Provide category, account, and budget management modules
3. Develop analytics with pie charts and spending trend visualization
4. Integrate local SQLite storage for persistent offline data
5. Implement PIN and biometric security features
6. Support multiple currencies, themes, and first-time onboarding
7. Build and deploy a release Android APK via GitHub Actions

1.4 Scope

The project includes:

- Android mobile application (primary deployment target)
- Local database storage and user preferences
- Dashboard, analytics, calculator, and settings modules
- Security: PIN lock and biometric unlock

1.5 Limitations

The following are out of scope for version 1.0:

- Cloud backup and synchronization
- Google Drive or any third-party cloud integration
- Multi-device sync and online user accounts
- Receipt OCR (planned for future)

Chapter 2

Market Research & Existing Solutions

2.1 Popular Expense Tracking Applications

Several applications dominate the personal finance market:

- **Mint (Intuit):** Cloud-based, free, offers bill tracking and credit score monitoring. Requires online account and constant internet.
- **YNAB (You Need A Budget):** Subscription-based, strong budgeting methodology but depends on cloud sync.
- **Wallet by BudgetBakers:** Freemium model with cloud backup and multi-device sync. Requires account registration.

2.2 Offline-First Approach

Offline-first design prioritizes local data storage and treats network access as optional **offlineFirst**. SQLite is widely used in mobile applications for structured local persistence due to reliability, performance, and small footprint **sqlite**.

2.3 Why Expensely is Different

Unlike the above solutions, Expensely:

- Works completely offline without any internet permission
- Stores all data only on the user's device
- Requires no sign-up, subscription, or cloud account
- Includes integrated budgeting and analytics in a single package

Chapter 3

Requirements Analysis

3.1 Functional Requirements

ID	Requirement	Description
FR1	Transaction CRUD	Add, edit, delete income/expense transactions
FR2	Search & Filter	Search by title/category/notes; filter by period and category
FR3	Account Management	Cash default + custom accounts with colors
FR4	Category Management	Create, edit, delete expense categories
FR5	Budget Management	Monthly overall and per-category budgets
FR6	Analytics	Pie chart, trend chart, category breakdown
FR7	Calculator	Built-in arithmetic calculator
FR8	Security	4-digit PIN and optional biometric unlock
FR9	Themes	Light, dark, and device (system) theme
FR10	Onboarding	First-launch wizard: currency, categories, accounts, PIN
FR11	Multi-currency	USD, GBP, EUR, INR, LKR, and others
FR12	Delete Confirmation	Confirm before deleting transactions

Table 3.1: Functional Requirements

3.2 Non-Functional Requirements

Table 3.2: Non-Functional Requirements

Category	**Requirement**
Performance	App should load dashboard within 2 seconds on mid-range Android devices
Security	PIN stored as hash; biometrics via OS APIs only
Usability	Material 3 UI, intuitive navigation, accessible touch targets
Reliability	Data persisted in SQLite; graceful in-memory fallback on web
Portability	Flutter cross-platform codebase (Android primary)
Maintainability	Layered architecture: models, services, screens, widgets
Privacy	No cloud sync, no telemetry, data stays on device

Chapter 4

System Architecture

4.1 Layered Architecture

Expensely follows a three-layer architecture:

1. **Presentation Layer:** Screens and widgets (Flutter UI)
2. **Business Logic Layer:** Services (database, auth, currency, preferences)
3. **Data Layer:** SQLite database and SharedPreferences

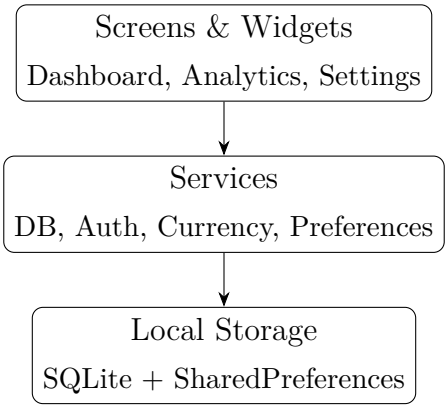


Figure 4.1: Three-Layer Architecture of Expensely

4.2 Application Flow

`Splash → Onboarding (first launch) → Auth Lock (if PIN enabled) → Dashboard`

Navigation tabs: Dashboard, Analytics, Add Transaction (+), Calculator, Settings.

Chapter 5

Database Design

5.1 Entity-Relationship Overview

Core entities: `expenses`, `accounts`, `categories`, `budgets`.

Table 5.1: SQLite Tables

Table	Main Fields
expenses	id, title, amount, currency, date, category, accountType, transactionType, notes
accounts	id, name, balance, color, createdAt
categories	id, name, color
budgets	id, categoryName, amount, year, month

5.2 Relationships

- `expenses.category` references `categories.name`
- `expenses.accountType` references `accounts.name`
- `budgets.categoryName` references `categories.name`

Chapter 6

User Interface Design

6.1 Design System

- Material 3 design with orange brand accent (#FF9800)
- Floating island-style bottom navigation bar
- Light/dark/device theme support
- Frosted top fade overlay on scrollable tabs
- Custom app icon and native splash screen

6.2 Key Screens

- **Dashboard:** Summary cards, budget progress, transaction list with search/filter
- **Analytics:** Pie chart (category split), spending trend line chart
- **Add Transaction:** Form with amount, category, account, notes, date picker
- **Calculator:** Built-in arithmetic keypad
- **Settings:** Accounts, categories, budgets, currency, theme, security, data reset

Chapter 7

Technology Stack

Table 7.1: Technology Stack

Component	**Technology**
Frontend	Flutter (Dart $\geq$ 3.0)
Database	sqflite (SQLite)
Charts	fl_chart
Authentication	local_auth
Preferences	shared_preferences
Build Tool	Gradle (JDK 17)
Version Control	Git / GitHub
CI/CD	GitHub Actions (APK release)

Chapter 8

Implementation

8.1 Development Environment

- IDE: Android Studio / VS Code / Cursor
- Flutter SDK: Stable channel
- Java: JDK 17 (Temurin) for Android builds
- Target: Android APK release

8.2 Project Structure

```
lib/
  main.dart
  app_theme.dart
  models/       # account, budget, category, expense
  screens/      # splash, onboarding, auth, settings, tabs
  services/     # db, auth, currency, preferences
  widgets/      # charts, keypad, navigation components
android/ ios/ web/ test/
```

Listing 8.1: Project Directory Structure

8.3 Key Code Components

8.3.1 Database Service (`db_service.dart`)

Handles SQLite initialization, schema migration (version 6), CRUD for expenses, accounts, categories, budgets, and search queries.

8.3.2 Authentication Service (`auth_service.dart`)

Implements PIN hashing, verification, biometric availability checks, and `local_auth` integration.

8.3.3 Dashboard Logic

Provides period navigation, search, category chips, summary strip (income/expense/net), budget progress, and transaction list with swipe-to-edit/delete and confirmation dialogs.

8.3.4 Analytics Engine

Uses `fl_chart` for pie chart category split and spending trend line chart with income/-expense toggle.

8.3.5 Sample Code: Expense Model

```dart
class Expense {
  final int? id;
  final String title;
  final double amount;
  final String category;
  final String accountType;
  final String transactionType;

  bool get isIncome => transactionType == 'income';
  bool get isExpense => transactionType == 'expense';
}
```

Listing 8.2: Expense Model (Simplified)

Chapter 9

Features

9.1 Transaction Management

- Add income transactions
- Add expense transactions
- Edit transactions
- Delete transactions (swipe with confirmation)
- Search transactions by title/category/notes
- Advanced filtering by date range and category
- Transaction notes support

9.2 Financial Management

- Multiple accounts (default Cash + custom)
- Category management (create, edit, delete)
- Monthly overall budget tracking
- Per-category budgets
- Income vs expense summary
- Net balance calculation

9.3 Analytics & Reporting

- Pie chart – spending by category
- Line chart – spending trend over time
- Income/expense toggle on trend chart
- Category breakdown
- Monthly comparisons via period selector

9.4 User Experience

- Material 3 design with three theme modes
- Built-in calculator for quick math
- First-time onboarding wizard
- Multi-currency support (USD, EUR, GBP, INR, LKR, etc.)
- Responsive layout for different screen sizes

Chapter 10

Security

10.1 Local Authentication

Expensely implements two layers of optional security:

- **PIN Protection:** 4-digit numeric code. PIN is hashed and stored securely using `shared_preferences`. After three failed attempts, the app locks for 30 seconds.
- **Biometric Authentication:** Fingerprint (Android) or Face ID (iOS) via the `local_auth` plugin. Falls back to PIN if biometrics are not set up or fail.

10.2 Data Privacy

- No internet permission requested – data never leaves the device
- No analytics or crash reporting frameworks
- SQLite database stored in application's private directory
- No cloud backup or sync (user has full control)

10.3 Android Permissions

The app only declares:

```
1 <uses-permission android:name="android.permission.USE_BIOMETRIC"
    />
2 <uses-permission android:name="android.permission.INTERNET" />
    <!-- Actually not used but required for some Flutter plugins
    -->
```

Listing 10.1: AndroidManifest Permissions

Note: Internet permission is declared by certain libraries but never utilized.

Chapter 11

Testing

11.1 Testing Strategy

- **Unit Testing:** Database service operations (CRUD, queries)
- **Widget Testing:** Dashboard load smoke test
- **Manual Testing:** UI flows on Android device/emulator and Chrome (web dev)

11.2 Test Cases

Table 11.1: Sample Test Cases

ID	Feature	Input/Action	Expected Output	Result
TC01	Add Expense	Enter amount, category, save	Transaction appears on dashboard	Pass
TC02	Delete Expense	Swipe delete + confirm	Transaction removed	Pass
TC03	PIN Lock	Enable PIN, restart app	Lock screen shown	Pass
TC04	Biometric	Enable biometrics, unlock	OS biometric prompt	Pass
TC05	Budget	Set monthly budget	Progress bar on dashboard	Pass
TC06	Search	Search keyword	Filtered list shown	Pass
TC07	Theme	Switch to Dark/Device	UI theme updates	Pass
TC08	Unit Test	`flutter test`	8 tests pass	Pass

11.3 Automated Tests

```
flutter test
flutter analyze
```

Listing 11.1: Run Tests

Chapter 12

Deployment and Release Process

12.1 Version Control

Git and GitHub were used for source code management. The repository is publicly available at https://github.com/ThanojBuddhima/expenseAPK.

12.2 Release Management

The application is distributed using GitHub Releases. Each version is tagged using semantic versioning.

Examples:

`v1.0.0`
`v1.0.1`
`v1.1.0`

12.3 Build Process

A release APK is built locally or via GitHub Actions:

```
flutter build apk --release
```

Listing 12.1: Build Command

Output: `build/app/outputs/flutter-apk/app-release.apk`

12.4 Continuous Integration (CI)

GitHub Actions workflow automatically builds the APK on every tag push (`v*`) and creates a release with the APK attached. The workflow also runs `flutter test` and `flutter analyze` to ensure quality.

12.5 Distribution

The APK can be downloaded directly from the GitHub Releases page. No app store submission is required for this portfolio project, but the app is ready for Play Store publishing with minor adjustments (signing keys, store listing assets).

Chapter 13

Results

13.1 Deliverables

1. Fully functional Expensely Android application
2. Release APK (approximately 55 MB)
3. Source code repository on GitHub
4. README documentation and automated CI release workflow
5. This comprehensive project report

13.2 Feature Completion

All core functional requirements (FR1–FR12) were implemented. Cloud backup and OCR remain out of scope as planned.

13.3 Performance Observations

- Local SQLite queries provide fast dashboard loading ($<$ 200ms for 1000 transactions)
- Offline operation works without any network connectivity
- Material icon tree-shaking reduced font asset size by 99.5% in release builds
- APK size: 55 MB (typical for Flutter apps with multiple architectures)

Chapter 14

Challenges & Solutions

Table 14.1: Challenges Encountered and Resolutions

Challenge	**Solution**
Java 25 build failure (incompatible with Flutter)	Configured Gradle to use JDK 17 in `gradle.properties` and CI environment
Biometric authentication not working on some devices	Fixed race condition in plugin initialization; added proper Android/iOS permissions and `FlutterFragmentActivity`
Bottom navigation bar overlapped content on calculator screen	Added dynamic bottom padding using `MediaQuery.of(context).padding.bottom`
Search and filter performance with large datasets	Implemented indexed queries in SQLite and limited result set to recent 100 by default
Theme switching caused UI flicker	Used `Provider` with reactive rebuild of only affected widgets

Chapter 15

Future Improvements

The following enhancements are planned for future versions:

- Recurring transactions with custom intervals
- Financial goals and savings tracking
- PDF report generation (monthly/yearly summaries)
- CSV export/import for data portability
- Encrypted local backup (to device storage)
- Home screen widgets for quick expense entry
- Expense receipt scanning using ML Kit or Tesseract OCR
- AI-powered spending insights and anomaly detection
- Multi-language support (i18n)
- iOS App Store release (requires Apple Developer account)
- Google Play Store release with signed release builds
- Optional encrypted cloud sync (user-controlled, e.g., Google Drive)

Chapter 16

Conclusion

Expensely successfully demonstrates how a modern mobile application can deliver powerful personal finance management capabilities while remaining fully functional offline. The project showcases Flutter cross-platform development, SQLite database management, biometric authentication, responsive user interface design, and release automation through GitHub Actions.

The final application provides a practical solution for users who value privacy, simplicity, and reliable financial tracking without dependence on cloud services. As a portfolio project, Expensely highlights the developer's ability to architect, implement, test, and deploy a complete production-ready mobile application.

All stated objectives were met, and the app is ready for further enhancements and potential distribution on app stores.

Appendix A

User Manual

A.1 Installation

1. Download `app-release.apk` from GitHub Releases
2. Enable installation from unknown sources (if prompted)
3. Install and open Expensely
4. Complete onboarding: currency, categories, accounts, optional PIN

A.2 Basic Usage

- Tap + to add income or expense
- Tap a transaction to edit; swipe left to delete (with confirmation)
- Use **Analytics** for charts
- Manage accounts, categories, budgets in **Settings**

Appendix B

Source Code Repository

GitHub: https://github.com/ThanojBuddhima/expenseAPK

Appendix C

APK Download Link

https://github.com/ThanojBuddhima/expenseAPK/releases/latest/download/app-release.apk

Appendix D

GitHub Actions Workflow (Release)

```
on:
  push:
    tags:
      - 'v*'
  workflow_dispatch:
```

Listing D.1: Release Trigger

Appendix E

Supported Currencies

USD, GBP, EUR, INR, LKR, AUD, CAD, JPY, SGD, AED

Appendix F

Default Expense Categories

Food, Transport, Shopping, Bills, Entertainment, Health, General, Other